/whatever you do

BEFORE YOU START

Workbook 2: How to use it

This is one of four workbooks that cover the middle of the course.

Your gifts How you've been designed - your strengths, according to you and others.

The space of your life Mapping your story, and what has happened in each season of it. **This workbook**

Expressing your calling Narrowing it to a sentence, then opening it back up.

Your growth plan Turning all of it into something you will actually do.

THREE THINGS WORTH REMEMBERING

This is not a test. Nobody marks it and nobody else reads it unless you choose to show them. An honest half-answer is worth more than a tidy one.

It is meant to be unhurried. Three or four sittings of half an hour is better than one long evening. The thinking needs time to settle.

You are not meant to do it alone. There are conversations with your coach built into each booklet. They matter more than any single page in it.

WHAT YOUR COACH IS FOR

A coach is not a mentor handing down their own experience. Their job is to ask questions and let you find your own answers. If they start telling you what they would do, it is entirely fair to point that out.

You will need a pen, a Bible, and somewhere you're unlikely to be interrupted. Your 'gifts and talents' results may not be fully complete, as it can take a while to get others to provide their assessments of you - don't let that stop you making progress on this workbook.

HOW TO GET THE MOST FROM THE BIBLE READINGS

These devotional materials are designed to provide the New Testament backdrop to your ongoing consideration of what Christian work and calling is.

Read them slowly. Read them multiple times. Pray through them. Underline bits, meditate on them. Memorise them, and write down what you sense the Holy Spirit might be saying to you as you do all of the above. The Bible passages, by definition, are God speaking. Embrace His words, listen as attentively as you can. To keep this sustainable, we'd recommend you swap it out for your quiet times, rather than treating it as additional material.

READING 1 OF 3

John 15: 1-16

Fruit comes from remaining

As saved people - those who are 'clean' (verse 3) - we are called to bear (lasting) fruit. But **we only bear fruit if we abide in the vine - Jesus**. Our fruitfulness is based on the Father's gardening work. Cutting out dead wood, and pruning back fruitful branches to increase future yield, look similar to the untrained eye. Our role is to cooperate with these (potentially painful) processes, remaining in and showing His love, obeying His commands.

> *"Our patterns of work and rest reveal what we believe to be true about God and ourselves. God alone requires no limits on his activity. To rest is to acknowledge that we humans are limited by design. We are created for rest just as surely as we are created for labour. An inability or unwillingness to cease from our labours is a confession of unbelief, an admission that we view ourselves as creator and sustainer of our own universes."*
>
> — Jen Wilkin, Ten Words to Live By: Delighting in and Doing What God Commands.

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— How 'connected' / 'rooted' in the vine are you at the moment? Why?

— What 'dead wood' is being cut out of your life? What good things are being 'pruned'?

— What do your rhythms of 'abiding' / 'remaining' in the vine look like?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship Jesus as the life-giver, the one who sustains us, and all things!

— Confess where you have tried to bear fruit on your own, away from the vine

— Ask the Holy Spirit to help you discern how you can be more rooted in Jesus, and - as a result - more fruitful

The shape of your life

God speaks to us about calling not just through gifting, but through your circumstances, the people around you, the things you've done that bear fruit, and your prayers.

This section maps the seasons of your life out, then overlays circumstances, people, fruit and prayer over the top. This allows common threads to become more visible.

Read these first

Psalm 139, especially v13–16	Your days were written before one of them came to be.
Esther 4, especially v14	For such a time as this — the right person in the right place.
Romans 5:3–5	What suffering produces, and in what order.
Proverbs 15:22	Why this is not a solitary exercise.
John 15:1-7, especially v16	Chosen and appointed, so that your fruit would last.

> Nothing in your story is wasted — the open doors, the closed ones, the people, the suffering, the fruit. Look back and notice what God has been doing.

Write the things that struck you in the readings:

STEP ONE

Map out the chapters of your story

Break your life into seasons. Start at birth and work forwards – childhood, school, training, jobs, moves, the big transitions. Rough is fine, the order is what matters, not dates or detail.

the season	a one line description of that season
↧ Early life	

↧

The season you are in now

If you're stuck, try asking where you were living, who you were spending time with, or what you were most interested in at that point.

STEP TWO

Lay your story over the top

Now go through your chapters and write out the key things that happened in each. Include things that a) were clearly very significant, b) things that you *know* pointed to your calling, and especially c) things that were both!

Next, mark each thing with one of the following letters so you can see the pattern later.

D	**Open door**	A context, a contact or an opportunity that opened up.
H	**Hardship & loss**	A hard season, a loss, a rejection, or a door that shut.
P	**Person**	Someone who shaped, affirmed or spoke into you.
F	**Lasting fruit**	Something you did that bore fruit which outlasted it.
L	**God's leading**	A scripture, a prayer, a burden, a sense of God speaking.
?	**Not sure**	Mark it anyway. You can work out what it was later.

TWO THINGS TO RESIST

Do not filter out the bad bits. The seasons you would rather skip are usually the ones carrying the most.

Do not only mark the big events. A sentence someone said to you in passing has changed more lives than most career decisions.

STEP TWO

Marking your chapters

the season	key parts of your story	letter
↧ Early life		

↧

The season you are in now

STEP THREE

What threads do you notice?

Step back and read everything you've written as one story rather than a list of events. Jot down the threads, then come back to this page again after you've slept or had time to mull it, reflecting and writing some more.

Reading it as a whole, the threads I notice are:

LOOK ACROSS YOUR TIMELINE

What keeps recurring? What has God been saying consistently?

Which chapter has the most marks on it? Formative seasons tend to be crowded. It is often not the one you would have guessed.

Is there a chapter holding both H and F? Worth asking what the one produced in the other. Where did suffering produce fruit *later*?

Where do the P marks cluster? What was it about that season that made you open to people? Who shows up at the turning points?

Which letter appears least? Is that because there is nothing there, or because it is harder to see?

Do the F marks follow the D marks? Did the fruit come from the open doors, or from somewhere else entirely?

READING 2 OF 3

Matthew 16: 24&25 (NIV)

Losing your life to find it

There is a huge danger in thinking of 'calling' in terms of self-actualisation. This can look like us trying to 'find ourselves'. But our 'calling' is **not about us**. It's not about the best possible career for our mix of strengths and abilities. All Christian calling on some level is to self-denial, in light of what Jesus has done.

The best possible outcome from considering your calling as a Christian is finding a practical expression of the gospel in your everyday life that is of such significance for time and eternity, and such a strong fit with your God-given gifts, that it is worth giving your life to in sacrifice.

We are not finding ourselves - we are finding life in Jesus, and living accordingly.

> *"When Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die."*
>
> — Deitrich Bonhoeffer, The Cost of Discipleship

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— What are your motivations for doing this course?

— Are there any areas of genuine self-denial in your life today? What specific self-denial might result from you growing in your apprenticeship to Jesus?

— What sacrifices have you seen, or read about, other Christians making that have inspired you?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship Jesus! He is not asking us to do anything He hasn't already done - His was the ultimate calling, the ultimate sacrifice, and the ultimate reward (see Hebrews 12:2)

— Confessing any times where you've made work and/or calling about you

— Asking for the Holy Spirit to empower you for any sacrifices Jesus might be calling you to make, as part of general discipleship, or as a result of this course

READING 3 OF 3

Matthew 25: 14-30

Stewarding what you were given

Jesus has **an expectation that we will be fruitful.** We are to steward the talents we've been given, for His benefit. We're given different quantities of talent, and these come with differing levels of responsibility. We also know from other passages such as 1 Peter 4:10-11, 1 Cor. 12:4-5, Romans 12:4-6, and Ephesians 4:11-13, that the talents (or gifts) we're given are of differing types. It's possible to grow in our gifting / talents - **when we're 'faithful in a little', He will entrust us with an opportunity to be 'faithful with much'.**

> *"Waiting for the Lord means our action is essential, but His is decisive. The farmer must wait for the harvest. But no one works harder than the farmer."*
>
> — Bryan Loritts, Letters to a Birmingham Jail

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— Do you have any ideas of what talents God has given you? Flick through the 'gift list' passages above for ideas. What might 'trading with' those talents look like in practice?

— Despite the importance of gifting, the biggest driver of the servants' fruitfulness wasn't the level or type of raw materials they were given, but their perception of, and relationship with, their master. Which of the servants' attitudes to God, and serving Him, are your own most like?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Every good thing we have is ultimately an unearned blessing from God. Thank Him!

— Confess areas where you sense your relationship with God being more like that of the third servant

— Ask for the Holy Spirit to reveal more of what Jesus' is like to you, and to begin to highlight how you might use your talents for His glory

CONVERSATION TWO

Talking it through

Show your coach the timeline before you go any further. Give them this page, and then add to your timeline based on the conversation with them.

FOR THE COACH · ABOUT 60 MINUTES

What this conversation is for

Helping them read their own story back, and notice the threads they are too close to see. You are not interpreting their life for them. You are asking, and then waiting.

EXAMPLE QUESTIONS TO ASK

"Walk me through this. Which chapter was hardest to write down?"
"Where do you see hardship and fruit sitting in the same season?"
"Who shows up at the turning points, and what did they see in you?"
"Which chapter do you think is the most pivotal to understanding your calling?"
"What is missing from this timeline that you chose not to include initially?"

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

Seasons of suffering are often where the clearest formation happened. Be gentle, and do not rush to make meaning of something still raw.

If a whole category is empty - no people, or no sense of God leading - that absence is worth asking about kindly.

AVOID Imposing your own reading of their story. Ask what they see before offering what you see.

To close, ask them what - if anything - they'd like to add to the sheet with their story on it.